



1. Introduction: A Report Is Not Finished When It Is Published

A Power BI report may contain accurate data, strong modelling, reliable DAX, clear visuals, and fast performance. But one important question remains: **Can the right people access the right information, and can the organisation trust what they are using?**

Publishing a report without considering access, security, ownership, and governance can lead to oversharing, duplicated content, inconsistent metrics, accidental exports, and reports that remain active long after they stop providing value.

In simple terms: **Security controls who can access the data and what they can do with it. Governance keeps Power BI content organised, reliable, monitored, and trustworthy.**

2. Workspaces

A Power BI workspace is a collaborative area in the Power BI Service where teams create, manage, organise, and publish reports, dashboards, semantic models, dataflows, and other content.

There are two common workspace experiences

My Workspace	Shared Workspace
My Workspace is a personal area intended for an individual user's content.	A shared workspace is used for team collaboration and managed content delivery
It is useful for: • Personal analysis • Learning and testing • Draft reports • Content that is not ready for team distribution	It allows organisations to: • Bring related reports and models together • Assign responsibilities to different users • Control who can edit or view content • Publish content through a Power BI app • Manage access through workspace roles

Power BI uses four primary workspace roles: **Admin, Member, Contributor, and Viewer.**

POWER BI WORKSPACE ROLE COMPARISON			
Role	Primary Purpose	Key Capabilities	Best For
 Admin	Full Manager	Can do everything, including deleting the workspace, managing permissions, and adding/removing other admins.	Workspace owners & IT lead
 Member	Co-Creator & Publisher	Can add/edit content, manage workspace users (non-admins), and publish/update Apps.	Senior developers & team leads
 Contributor	Content Creator	Can create, edit, and delete reports/datasets inside the workspace. Cannot publish or update Apps.	Regular report developers & analysts
 Viewer	Consumer	Can only view and interact with reports and dashboards in the workspace. Cannot edit or see datasets behind the scenes.	Stakeholders & business users who need direct workspace access

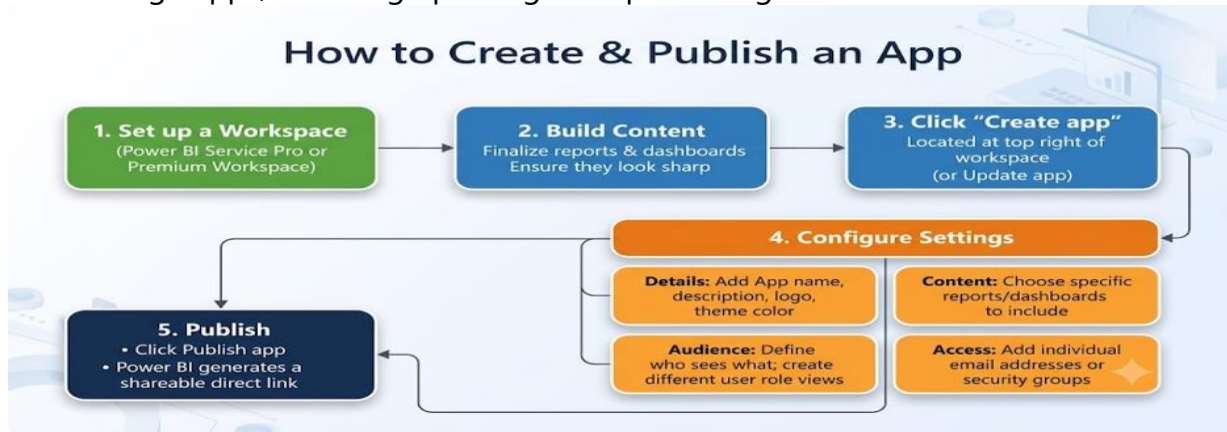
3. Apps

A Power BI app is a packaged collection of reports, dashboards, and related content distributed to business users through a controlled interface.

Think of an app as a clean digital binder. Instead of sharing multiple workspace links individually, the report team publishes selected content as one organised experience.

Apps are useful because the workspace remains the development and collaboration area, while the app becomes the consumption layer for end users. Workspace Admins and Members can publish and manage apps, including updating or unpublishing them.

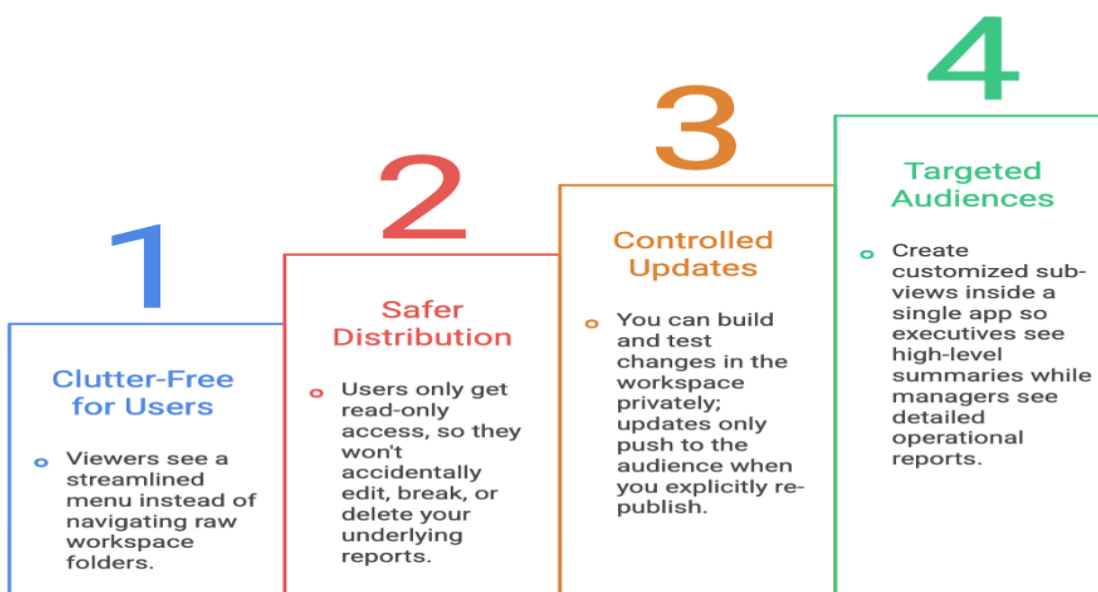
How to Create & Publish an App



How to Manage an App

Action	 Update Content	 Control Permissions	 Unpublish
Description	Edit reports in workspace and click Update app to publish	Add or remove user access via Permissions tab	Remove deprecated apps from the workspace menu

Advantages of Using Apps



4. Row-Level Security

Row-level security, or **RLS**, restricts which rows of data a user can see inside a Power BI semantic model.

Everyone can open the same report and view the same layout, but the data displayed changes according to the user's assigned role. For example:

- A Victorian manager sees only Victorian records.
- A regional sales manager sees only their own territory.

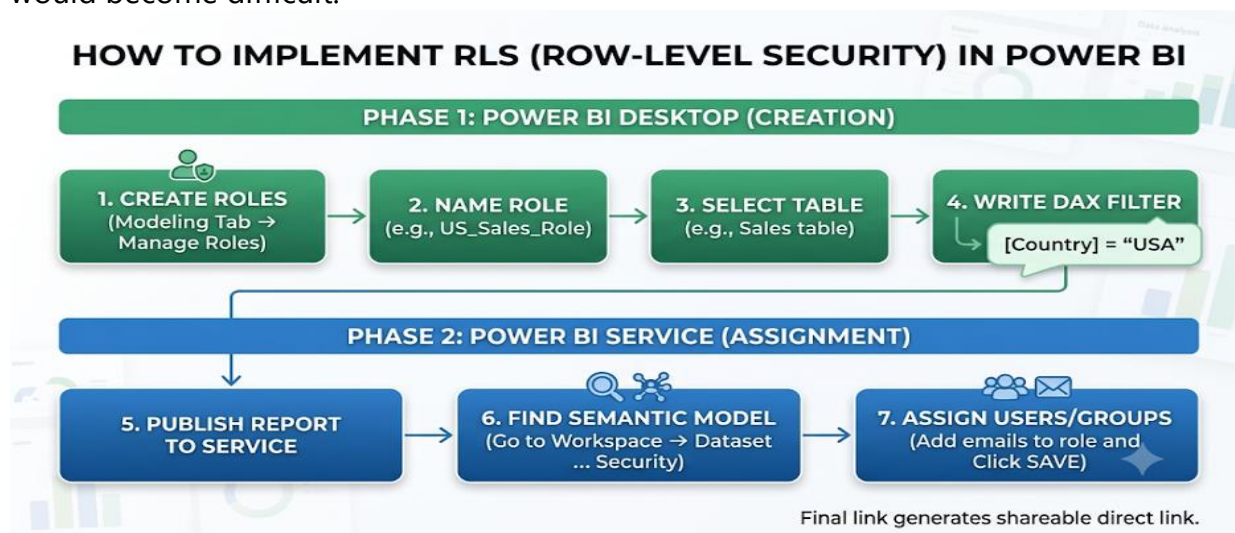
Everyone sees the same report design, same table headers, and same visual charts-they just see **different subsets of data** (horizontal filtering).

Static and Dynamic RLS

Static RLS uses fixed roles, such as Australia, United Kingdom, or Finance.

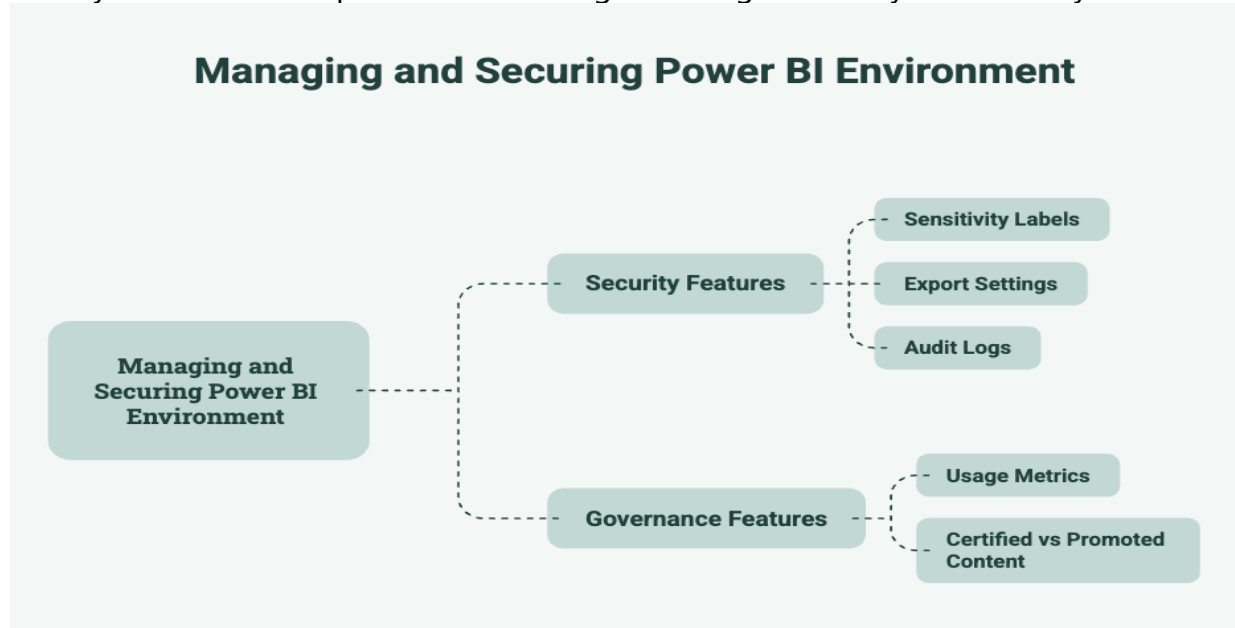
Dynamic RLS uses the identity of the logged-in user to determine which records should be visible, often through functions such as `USERPRINCIPALNAME()` and a user-access mapping table.

Use dynamic RLS when many users need different views and manually maintaining separate roles would become difficult.



5. Managing and Securing the Power BI Environment

Security and governance continue beyond workspace access and RLS. Organisations also need to classify data, control exports, monitor usage, investigate activity, and identify trusted reports.



Security helps prevent unauthorised access and accidental leaks, while governance keeps Power BI content organised, reliable, discoverable, and maintainable.

5.1 Security Features: Data Protection

These features help determine who can access data, how it can leave Power BI, and how activity is monitored.

Sensitivity Labels

- **What it is:** Digital security tags (like *Public*, *Confidential*, or *Highly Confidential*) applied to reports and datasets.
- **Why it matters:** They signal how carefully data should be handled. When you export a report to Excel, PDF, or PowerPoint, the sensitivity label (and its file protection/encryption) travels along with the exported file.

Audit Logs

- **What it is:** A system activity history log tracked by IT admins.
- **Why it matters:** Records behind-the-scenes actions-such as who deleted a report, changed security permissions, or exported data-for compliance and security investigations.

Export Settings

- **What it is:** Admin controls that determine whether users can download data out of Power BI (e.g., exporting to Excel, downloading .pbix files, or printing).
- **Why it matters:** Prevents accidental or intentional data leaks by blocking users from saving raw company data onto personal devices.

5.2 Governance Features: Management and Trust

These features help keep Power BI content organised, useful, discoverable, and reliable.

Usage Metrics

- **What it is:** Built-in dashboard statistics showing who is viewing a report, how often they open it, and performance trends (e.g., page load speeds).
- **Why it matters:** Helps report creators see if their audience is actually using their reports or if an unused report can be retired.

Certified vs. Promoted Content

Power BI uses **Endorsements** to help users know which data they can trust:

-  **Promoted:** A "head's up" badge applied by report creators to signal that a dataset or report is ready and recommended for others to use.
-  **Certified:** An official stamp of approval given *only* by authorized IT/data admins to confirm the data is accurate, verified, and safe for enterprise decision-making.

6. Practical Way to Decide



Practical Way to Decide

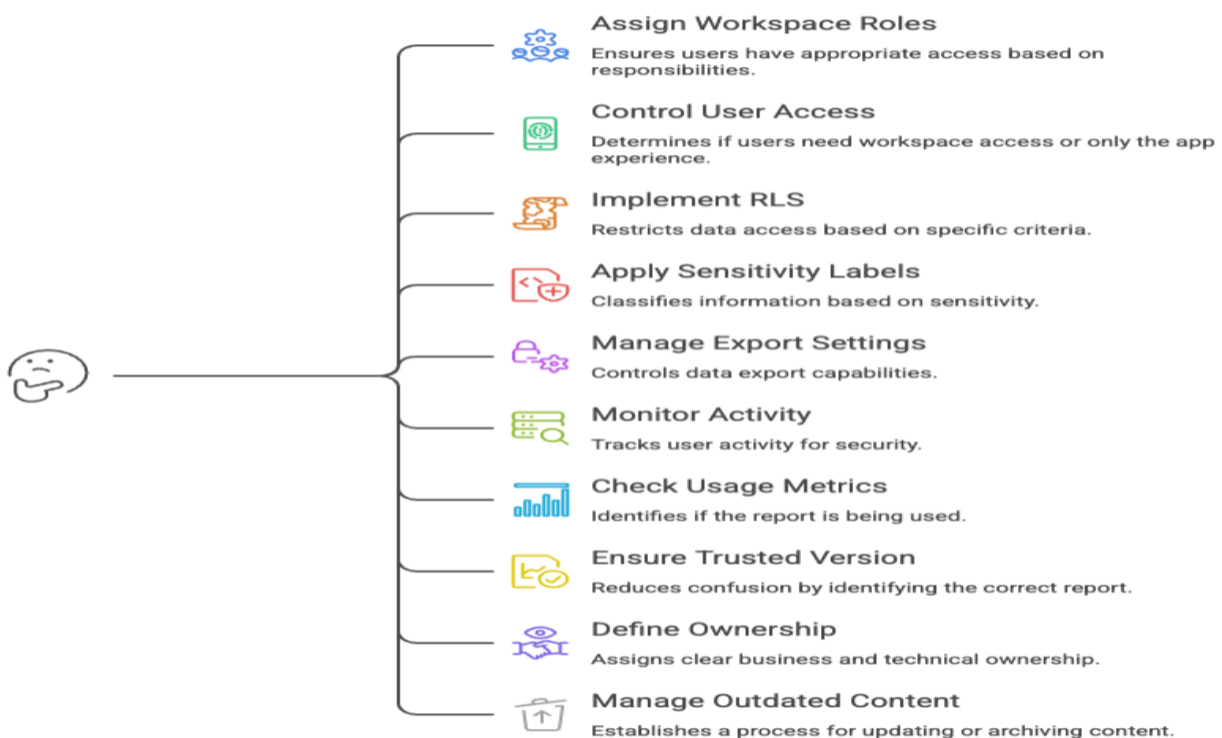
Choose the right Power BI option for the outcome you need.

1 SHARED WORKSPACE		Use a shared workspace when: A team needs to collaborate on reports, models, and app content.
2 VIEWER ACCESS		Use Viewer access when: Users need to consume workspace content without editing it, particularly when RLS must apply.
3 POWER BI APP		Use a Power BI app when: You need to distribute a curated and stable reporting experience to a wider audience.
4 RLS		Use RLS when: Users should open the same report but see different rows based on their responsibilities.
5 SENSITIVITY LABELS		Use sensitivity labels when: Content must be classified and remain protected through supported export paths.
6 RESTRICT EXPORTS		Restrict exports when: Users may view information but should not download sensitive data.
7 AUDIT LOGS		Use audit logs when: You need to investigate user actions, permission changes, exports, or compliance events.
8 USAGE METRICS		Use usage metrics when: You need to understand adoption and identify valuable or unused reports.
9 PROMOTE CONTENT		Promote content when: It is useful and recommended but has not completed formal organisational verification.
10 CERTIFY CONTENT		Certify content when: It has passed formal review and should be treated as an authoritative source.



Make better Power BI decisions. Secure, govern, and deliver with confidence.

7. What Analysts Should Ask



8.Conclusion

Security and governance determine whether a Power BI environment remains safe, trusted, and manageable after reports are published.

Workspaces define collaboration, apps provide controlled distribution, and RLS ensures users see the appropriate data. Sensitivity labels and export controls help protect information, while audit logs, usage metrics, and endorsements help organisations monitor activity, manage adoption, and identify authoritative content.

A strong Power BI analyst does not only build and publish reports. They also consider **who should access them, what those users should see, how the data should be protected, and how the content will remain trusted over time.**

Stay tuned for the next article in **The Insight Stack: Power BI, Layer by Layer**, where we move into **Week 12: Decision Systems** and explore how Power BI reports become reliable, reusable tools that support ongoing business decisions.